

Cafe Barra Partner Selection Framework

Purpose

This framework helps Cafe Barra determine whether a cafe is a **strong strategic partner** or a **commodity wholesale account**.

Cafe Barra prioritizes **alignment over volume**.

The goal is to build a partner network where coffee strengthens the cafe's identity and customer experience.

Partner Fit Scorecard

Score each category 1–5

Category	Key Question	1 (Poor Fit)	3 (Moderate Fit)	5 (Ideal Fit)
Brand Intent	Does the cafe treat coffee as part of its identity?	Coffee is commodity	Coffee is important	Coffee central to brand
Quality Standards	Do they actively manage coffee quality?	No dial-in discipline	Occasional attention	Active quality management
Training Culture	Do they train baristas intentionally?	No training	Informal training	Structured training
Partnership Orientation	Do they want collaboration with a roaster?	Transactional	Neutral	Collaborative
Operational Discipline	Can they execute consistently?	No systems	Partial routines	Clear procedures
Volume Viability	Is the account viable long-term?	Very small	Moderate	Strong volume

Communication	Are they organized and responsive?	Disorganized	Inconsistent	Professional
Strategic Alignment	Do their priorities match Barra philosophy?	Misaligned	Neutral	Strong alignment

Score Interpretation

Total Score	Recommendation
32–40	Ideal Cafe Barra Partner
24–31	Promising Candidate – Validate
16–23	Weak Fit – Proceed Carefully
8–15	Decline Partnership

Immediate Red Flags

Decline partnerships if a cafe:

- prioritizes lowest price above quality
- refuses staff training
- treats suppliers as interchangeable vendors
- cannot maintain basic quality standards
- has chaotic communication or ordering processes

Cafe Barra Partner Philosophy

Cafe Barra partners with cafes that want coffee to:

- strengthen their brand
- create memorable customer experiences
- deliver consistent quality
- build long-term reputation

Coffee should make a cafe more distinctive and desirable—not dilute its brand.

Cafe Barra Partner Discovery Interview Guide

Purpose

This guide helps Cafe Barra evaluate potential partners through **structured conversations**.

Each section corresponds to the **Partner Fit Scorecard**, ensuring the discussion produces the information needed for evaluation.

The tone should remain **collaborative and conversational**, not interrogative.

1. Brand Intent

Goal

Understand whether coffee plays a role in the cafe's **identity and positioning**.

Questions

- What role does coffee play in the identity of your cafe?
- When customers think about your cafe, what do you hope they associate it with?
- How important is the coffee program to the experience you're creating?

Strong Signals

Owner references:

- experience
- reputation
- craft
- destination

Warning Signs

Coffee described as:

- purely functional
- just another beverage

2. Coffee Quality Mindset

Goal

Determine how seriously the cafe takes **quality and consistency**.

Questions

- How do you currently dial in espresso?
- Who is responsible for dialing in each day?
- How often do you taste drinks to check quality?

Strong Signals

- active dial-in process
- lead barista or owner responsible
- tasting culture

Warning Signs

- “we set it once and leave it”
- quality varies by shift

3. Staff Training Culture

Goal

Evaluate how the cafe develops **barista skill**.

Questions

- How do you train new baristas?
- Do you run tasting or calibration sessions?
- What’s hardest about maintaining drink consistency?

Strong Signals

- structured onboarding
- curiosity about coffee
- investment in training

Warning Signs

- informal training only
- high turnover without training process

4. Partnership Orientation

Goal

Determine whether the cafe wants a **relationship with their roaster**.

Questions

- What do you value most in a coffee supplier?
- What worked well or poorly with past roasters?
- What support do you wish roasters provided more often?

Strong Signals

- collaboration
- calibration help
- long-term partnership

Warning Signs

- focus entirely on price
- supplier treated as interchangeable

5. Operational Discipline

Goal

Assess whether the cafe can **execute quality consistently**.

Questions

- Do you track espresso recipes?
- How do you maintain machines and grinders?
- Do you have procedures for dialing in new coffees?

Strong Signals

- documented recipes
- maintenance routines
- consistent standards

Warning Signs

- no written processes
- reactive approach to quality

6. Volume and Growth Potential

Goal

Determine whether the account supports the **depth of partnership Cafe Barra provides**.

Questions

- How much coffee do you go through weekly?
- Has your volume been growing?
- Do you see your coffee program expanding?

Strong Signals

- healthy drink sales
- coffee central to menu
- growth trajectory

Warning Signs

- coffee is minor menu item
- low beverage sales

7. Communication and Responsiveness

Goal

Ensure the partnership will be **easy to manage operationally**.

Questions

- Who manages supplier relationships?
- How do you prefer to communicate with partners?
- If something goes wrong with the coffee, how do you handle it?

Strong Signals

- clear point of contact
- organized ordering
- responsive communication

Warning Signs

- unclear responsibilities
- irregular communication

8. Strategic Alignment

Goal

Confirm alignment with **Cafe Barra philosophy**.

Questions

- What makes a coffee program memorable?
- What role do you want coffee to play in the future of the cafe?
- Where do you want the cafe to be in five years?

Strong Signals

- long-term thinking
- brand ambition
- curiosity about coffee

Warning Signs

- purely short-term focus
- cost-only mindset

Final Step

Immediately complete the **Partner Fit Scorecard**.

Score	Action
32–40	Strong Partner Candidate
24–31	Validate Further
16–23	Weak Fit
<16	Decline Partnership